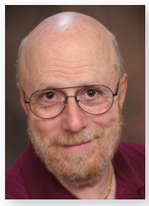
PHOTOGRAPHS BY KURT HERTZOG

Working with shell

Kurt Hertzog looks at using various types of shell in his turned work

KURT HERTZOG



Kurt is a professional woodturner, demonstrator and teacher and writes for various woodturning and woodworking publications in the United States as well as contributing to *Woodturning* magazine. He is on the Pen Makers' Guild Council and is past president of the American Association of Woodturners (AAW).

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As we've been exploring materials and colouration techniques a bit out of the normal woodturning, I'd like to continue this month with the use of shell. Of course we can't turn the shell in the traditional sense of cutting away and creating shape with our lathe and turning tools. We can remove shell material to refine the shape or create interesting features. If we don't feel inclined to cut, pierce or mechanically alter the shell, we can simply paint or dye the shell. When I speak of shell, I don't really put bounds on which types. It can be egg shells, sea shells or anything else in the category. This month, let's explore a few of the types of shells and how we might integrate them into our turnings.

Safety

Working with shell may seem pretty innocuous but there are some special considerations. Depending on whether you are cleaning the shells or buying them already prepared, you'll need to be aware of any hazards of disposing of the animal contents and cleaning the shells. Protective gloves and good hand cleansing practices are in order. I always disinfect any of the shells that I process with a stiff mixture of bleach and water followed by a good rinsing and drying. I don't know if this is necessary but I want to protect subsequent handlers from any hazards. Of course, the standard eye protection is in order when working with any tools and cutting processes. Breathing protection is particularly important when creating any shell dust and debris. Ingesting these particles needs to be prevented. Check your dust mask to be certain it is filtering to the correct particle size depending on your process. Each type of shell and process may create different sized particle dust. Ignorance of hazards may take years to become evident. Be certain you are taking the appropriate safety measures now.

In addition to the usual PPE, use dust extraction and breathing protection when working with shell

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